SMART AIDES WE LEAN ON

Combining voice recognition and generative AI, smart assistants have seduced millions of Indians with a wide variety of practical—and even emotional—help they offer. However, privacy concerns remain a serious worry

By **Sonali Acharjee** | Illustration by **Nilanjan Das**

First, there was the simple voice assistant, exemplified by the earliest Alexa, straining its ears to understand and play a song of one's choice or fetch basic information. Now, added with the aggregative and interpretative power of Artificial Intelligence (AI) tools like machine learning and natural language processing (NLP), your voice assistants have just become smarter. And, with these assistants embedded in their capacious smartphones, Indians are embracing their seemingly all-encompassing companionship. It seems natural to those who turn to this new league of voice assistants powered by generative AI—which use neural networks to identify patterns and structures within existing text, image, audio and video data to generate new content—for just about everything. From weekly shopping lists to counting calories on their plate and crafting arguments—nothing is beyond its ken.

60
Percentage of Indian smartphone users who use voice assistants

₹958 CRORE
Estimated size of Indian Indian voice assistant market in 2023, according to Grand View Research

Vidhushi Dalmia, 58, says the oddity of her 88-year-old mother, a dementia patient, spending all her time conversing with a voice assistant has faded. "It helps her stay active. For example, the AI in her Alexa device remembers her favourite songs long after she herself has forgotten them," says the homemaker from Delhi. Similarly, for Varun Nathvani, 28, his voice assistant is the wingman who helps him write poems for his girlfriend and sort out his professional crises. "I have to ask my device—'tell me how to convince my father that I didn't damage the car' or 'can you write a love poem about loyalty' or 'if I don't pass my UPSC exams what should I do'." Nathvani says he has shared a lot about himself and the people in his life with the device. "Now it reasons through all that and gives me answers. I would rather be without a home than my voice assistant," says Nathvani, a student from Mumbai who uses the ChatGPT-powered Siri on his iPhone.

The prominence of new voice assistants is not a surprise to experts. Speaking over typing has been in vogue for a while. In 2018, a PwC report found that, globally, 71 per cent prefer voice over typing for searching through their gadgets. "Voice assistants are bringing millions of Indians online, many of whom are first-time internet users. A large number of users of our voice assistant on JioPhone rely on it to search for content," says Vivekananda Pani, co-founder, Reverie Language Technologies, an AI-first language technology firm which creates text-based content in 23 official Indian languages.

Other than in smartphones, smart